

Italy Itinerary

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Rome: Ancient Stones, Trevi Coins & the Perfect Gelato

After wrapping up our Spain and Portugal adventures, I was buzzing with excitement for the Italian leg of our trip—and the final stretch of our European journey. I was hoping for better weather, some sunshine, and a whole lot of pasta.

We had our **first internal flight in Europe** on the morning of April 3rd—Barcelona to Rome at 7:15 AM. To make things easier, we stayed near the airport the night before. The plan was to catch the 4 AM bus; missing it would mean an expensive cab ride. Thankfully, the bus stop was right outside our hotel, and as soon as we reached it, the bus arrived. A good omen.

At the airport, we faced our first challenge: self-check-in for luggage. No staff at the counters, just machines. It made me wonder—why don't we have this in India? Is it because labor is cheaper, or are we just not there yet in terms of tech adoption? Either way, it was a moment of reflection.

As always, Harshit and I had our little argument—our approaches to problem-solving are very different, and travel tends to bring that out. But we figured it out, checked in, and waited at the gate. I noticed groups of school students flying out on trips to other European countries. For them, it was just another school outing. For me, it was a reminder of how far I've come. My 18-year-old self would never have imagined standing in Rome at 30.

The flight was short—just two hours—and I slept through most of it. When we landed in Rome, I felt a wave of emotion. I've seen this city in so many films, romanticized and larger than life. And now, I was here.

Getting from the airport to the city was another debate—bus or train? We chose the bus. Harshit slept, but I stayed awake, watching the city roll by. The weather was perfect – sunny and breezy.

Our Airbnb host was late, so we waited outside until a delivery guy let us in. We dropped our bags in the hallway, got ready there, and stepped out to explore **Rome with our 24 hour Roma Pass** in hand.

And wow—Rome was crowded. Coming from India, I don't expect European cities to feel packed, but Rome was an exception. It made me realize that population challenges aren't unique to us. For the first time, we saw ticket inspectors on public transport, and I understood why—many people weren't validating their tickets.

We kicked off our Roman adventure the way every proper Italian dream should—with **pizza and pasta**. And yes, the hype is real. The crust was crisp in all the right places, the sauce tasted like it had been kissed by summer tomatoes, and the pasta? Silky, savory, unapologetically indulgent. Italy doesn't serve food—it serves emotion.

And then came our first gelato—**Romeo Gelateria**, tucked near the **Spanish Steps**, where we dipped into creamy magic that instantly became a non-negotiable addiction. From that moment onward, **gelato became our official sidekick**, appearing in side streets, after museum walks, or just because the sun decided to show up.

Rome started with carbs and cream. No better beginning.

Day 1

Roman Icons — Your Walk Through History (and Hilarity)

From coins in fountains to crumbling empires and cinematic gelato breaks, these were the stars of our Rome story:

Spanish Steps

- **Misnamed elegance:** Despite their name, they're French-funded and not Spanish! They're named after the nearby Piazza di Spagna.
- **Fashion & Film:** The steps host glam shoots and once saw Audrey Hepburn sparkle in *Roman Holiday*.
- **Sit at your own risk:** Sitting is banned now to preserve the site. You can snap selfies, not snooze.
- **Keats House:** Just beside the steps sits the final residence of poet John Keats—now a museum of dreams and melancholia.

■ *When you climb these, you're also climbing into a poem.*

Trevi Fountain

- **Three coins, three fates:** Toss one to return to Rome, two to fall in love, and three to get married. At least that's what the legends say.
- **Big charity splash:** Over €1 million annually is collected from fountain coins and donated to those in need.
- **Oceanus, not Neptune:** That towering figure is actually Oceanus—the sea god in dramatic marble.
- **Cinematic stunner:** Featured in *La Dolce Vita* and *The Lizzie McGuire Movie*. One is culture, the other is... also culture.

■ *It's not just a fountain—it's a wishing well with architectural abs.*

Colosseum

- **Rome's ancient stadium:** Built in 80 AD, it hosted gladiator combat, wild animal hunts, and the world's bloodiest entertainment.
- **Flooded for naval battles:** Yep, they made it waterproof for showdowns on ships.
- **The Hypogeum:** A spooky underground maze where lions and warriors waited to be unleashed.
- **Still standing tall:** Despite earthquakes, fires, and tourists with broken phone hinges (looking at you, Harshit), it's the largest amphitheater ever built.

■ *The drama's faded, but the echoes still thunder.*

Pantheon

- **The dome to end all domes:** Still the largest unreinforced concrete dome on the planet. No steel. Just skill.
- **Perfect proportions:** It's a giant sphere sliced in half—equal in height and diameter.
- **Sky hole magic:** The oculus lets in sunlight, rain, and occasional divine vibes.
- **Resting legends:** Raphael lies here, alongside Italy's royal dignitaries.

■ *Even closed, it feels like it's whispering secrets.*

Vatican City

- **Tiny but mighty:** Just 44 hectares—smaller than many malls—but home to priceless art, power, and spiritual gravity.
- **Michelangelo's masterpiece:** He painted the Sistine Chapel ceiling standing up, not lying down (thanks to Hollywood myth busting).
- **World's oldest post office:** You can send a postcard that arrives faster than Roman buses.
- **Art marathon:** The Vatican Museums stretch over **9 miles**. Wear good shoes and prepare to gasp often.
- **No babies allowed:** Vatican citizenship depends on your job. No births happen here—only positions filled.

■ *It's more than the Pope—it's a palace of world history packed into a postage stamp.*

We ended our final Roman night the way only true Italy travelers do—one more **pizza**, and then the **grand finale: Tiramisu at Two Sizes**. We tried every flavor. We overcommitted. And not once did we regret it. Even now, I find myself craving those creamy spoonfuls like they're memories I want to taste again.

I'd planned to dedicate an entire post to Italian food—and honestly, I still might. But if there's one truth that echoed through every city, every café, and every plate... it's this: **In Italy, food isn't part of the story—it *is* the story.**

That evening, we returned to our apartment early, prepping for a **6:30 a.m. train to Amalfi**. Rome had been **intense, beautiful, a little chaotic**, and completely unforgettable. It left us full—not just with food, but with **moments**, laughter, and a kind of quiet **gratitude** that only travel knows how to serve.

Must-Visit Places in ROME

If you ever find yourself in Rome, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Colosseum:** Step back in time at this ancient amphitheater.
- **Vatican City:** Visit St. Peter's Basilica and the Sistine Chapel.
- **Trevi Fountain:** Toss a coin and make a wish at this Baroque fountain.
- **Pantheon:** Marvel at this ancient Roman temple.
- **Roman Forum:** Explore the ruins of ancient Rome.
- **Piazza Navona:** Enjoy the lively atmosphere of this Baroque square.
- **Spanish Steps:** Climb these iconic steps.
- **Villa Borghese:** Relax in this beautiful public park.

Venice: Canals, Chaos & the Best Gelato Ever

We arrived in **Venice** just as the canals caught their first shimmer of morning light. Often called the *Paris of Italy*, the city felt like a waking dream—**romantic**, **chaotic**, and eager to surprise us at every corner.

Our Airbnb check-in wasn't until 2 p.m., but the host—bless him—allowed us in early so we could freshen up and drop our bags. Two hours later, as we stepped out, he raised an eyebrow: *"I thought you said 20 minutes?"* We were just as confused. Maybe it was lost in translation. Or maybe we got lost in our own reflections. Venice does that to you.

Hungry and with a loosely sketched plan, we hopped on a **bus without tickets** – something we'd learned is not uncommon in Italy (though probably not recommended). The weather was a welcome contrast to Porto and Lisbon: **a soft blend of sun and chill**, like Venice knew we deserved a little kindness.

Our first food stop was closed—**classic Sunday curveball**. So we wandered toward the city's heart, following narrow alleys, gondola glides, and curious sights. One detail caught us off guard: **clothes strung between buildings**. A rare sight in Europe, but here in Venice, it felt poetic—**daily life woven into fairytale views**.

We were staying a bit outside the main island, in what locals might call the **"tail" of Venice** (yes, it's shaped like a fish!). It's cheaper, quieter, and gave us a more authentic pulse of the place. On the way, we stumbled into a **supermarket**—which, for me, is like Dmart's European cousin. I can't resist them. We stocked up on chocolates, cold drinks, and the kind of small comforts that rescue you from overpriced tourist traps. Grocery shopping in a foreign country has its own thrill. There's something grounding about it—it makes you feel less like a visitor and more like a local-in-training.

Eventually, we stumbled upon **I Love Italy**, and the **pasta** served there was nothing short of divine. Creamy. Rich. Utterly unforgettable. Even now, I taste it like a bookmarked page in my memory.

Then came **gelato**. We skipped the flashy spots and found a tiny old-school gelateria—no frills, just **magic in cones**. Chocolate and pistachio. Fruit sorbet and dark chocolate. Each flavor a gentle confession from Italy.

Day 1

Venetian Bridges & Plazas — Our Walk Through History

Venice is a labyrinth of water, held together by hundreds of bridges, each with its own story, style, and secrets. Here are the iconic highlights we explored during our unforgettable day:

Rialto Bridge

Venice's oldest and most famous bridge, the Rialto is like the city's grand old storyteller.

- Built in **1591**, it replaced a wooden version that kept collapsing (oops).
- Designed by **Antonio da Ponte**, who beat out Michelangelo for the job—talk about underdog glory!
- It's made of **Istrian stone**, and has shops lining both sides, so yes, you can literally shop on a bridge.
- Legend says the architect made a **pact with the devil** to keep the bridge standing. The price? The soul of the first person to cross it... which turned out to be his wife. ■

Bridge of Sighs

This isn't your average romantic bridge—it's got a dark twist.

- Built in **1603**, it connects the **Doge's Palace** to the **prison**.
- Prisoners would cross it after sentencing, catching their **last glimpse of Venice** through its tiny stone-barred windows. Hence, the "sighs."
- Ironically, it's now a **symbol of eternal love**—legend says if you kiss under it at sunset while the bells toll, your love will last forever.
- Casanova himself crossed it... and escaped prison. Classic.

Legend says that if a couple kisses in a gondola under the Bridge of Sighs at sunset while the church bells toll, they will be granted eternal love and happiness.

Ponte dell'Accademia

The artsy rebel of Venice's bridges.

- One of only **four bridges** that span the Grand Canal.
- Originally built in **1854** as a steel bridge, but Venetians hated it. So in **1933**, they replaced it with a **wooden one**—which they still love.
- It offers **the best view** of the Grand Canal, especially at sunset.
- Once covered in **love locks**, but the city cracked down to save the bridge's structure. Love is eternal, but wood isn't.

St. Mark's Square (Piazza San Marco)

Venice's living room—and Napoleon's favorite.

- Called "**the drawing room of Europe**" by Napoleon, it's the city's social and spiritual heart.
- Home to **St. Mark's Basilica**, the **Campanile**, and the **Doge's Palace**.
- Floods regularly thanks to its low elevation—locals call it "**Aqua Alta**", and tourists call it "Oops, my shoes."
- The square is also famous for its **pigeons**, orchestras, and the legendary **Caffè Florian**, which has been serving espresso since **1720**.

Before retreating to our apartment (nearly an hour away, ticket skipped again—we'll repent in another country), we did one last round of "**Dmart**" **shopping**: chocolates, olive oil, cinnamon—souvenirs that smell like tomorrow's nostalgia.

Dinner was quiet and cozy—our first taste of **risotto**, and yes, we liked it. As we packed, we realized this was our **last full day in Italy**.

Only **24 hours** in Venice. Just a single day. But somehow, it was enough.

Enough to feel the pull of its pulse. Enough to be surprised, comforted, filled. Enough to remember it always.

Must-Visit Places in Venice

If you ever find yourself in Venice, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **St. Mark's Basilica:** Admire the Byzantine architecture.
- **Grand Canal:** Take a water taxi or gondola ride along the main waterway.
- **Rialto Bridge:** Cross this historic stone bridge and shop.
- **Doge's Palace:** Tour this magnificent Venetian Gothic palace.
- **Piazza San Marco:** Relax and watch the orchestras in the central square.
- **Murano Island:** Watch glass-blowing artisans at work.
- **Burano Island:** Wander among the famous bright, colorful houses.
- **Ponte dell'Accademia:** Snap the iconic postcard view of Grand Canal.

Florence & Pisa: Missed Stops, Magical Pizza & a Day of Surprises

Day 1

Arrival — Missed Stops & a Bologna Detour

Our journey to Florence began with a 6:15 AM bus from Naples. We were expecting a smooth ride and a scenic morning nap, but little did we know, the day had other plans.

As the bus rolled through the Italian countryside, we dozed off, occasionally waking to admire the views. And then, at 12:15, the bus stopped at **Firenze Villa Costanza**. We saw the name but convinced ourselves it couldn't be Florence. Google Maps told us our stop was still an hour away, and as seasoned GPS-trusting travelers, we stayed seated. Harshit even asked a passenger about Florence, and that's when reality hit: We'd missed our stop. Not just the stop. **The entire city.**

The next halt? **Bologna**. Another region. Another state. Another two hours of wondering how exactly we graduated from "almost there" to "absolutely somewhere else."

So we sat back, mentally recalibrating. In transit, we searched options. Thankfully, Bologna's bus station was next to a train station, so getting back to Florence wouldn't be impossible. But as soon as we stepped off the bus, fate smiled: a **Flixbus heading back to Florence** was waiting. The driver charged us **€40 (no ticket, no drama)** and let us hop in.

Inside the bus, Harshit chatted with an Indian man from North India who shared stories of how people enter Italy illegally and survive here. Even on accidental detours, you meet people whose stories stretch your worldview. By **3 p.m.**, we finally reached Florence – two cities later, a few euros poorer, and definitely richer in ridiculous memories.

Our apartment host was an elderly Italian gentleman who didn't speak a word of English. But thanks to gestures and the universal language of tired travellers seeking a warm bed, we made it work. With barely time to breathe, we rushed to catch our pre-booked train to Pisa at 4 PM.

We landed in Florence not for Florence—but for Pisa. That was always the plan: click some iconic photos, absorb a few scenic moments, and then head back to base.

By 4 p.m., we boarded our **pre-booked train to Pisa**—a beautiful 1.5-hour ride winding through Tuscan fields and quiet hills. Europe knows how to paint the earth green. On the train, we met a **mother-daughter duo** who'd visited India and instantly connected over shared laughter. They gave us tips on chocolates and cafés—tiny kindnesses that feel big when you're far from home.

And then **Pisa** happened.

It reminded me of **Pune**, but a quieter, cleaner version of it. Framed by mountains, low on traffic, full of wide streets and uninterrupted sky. No dense buildings. Just earth, air, and old stone.

From the station, we hopped on a bus and rushed toward the icon itself—the **Leaning Tower of Pisa**. At first glance, it peeked shyly from behind the Pisa Cathedral, shorter than we'd imagined. Not towering like the Eiffel that dominates every frame of Paris. It was humbler. Quieter. But stunning in its own way.

So we did what every tourist does. **Photos. All kinds. All angles. All weird poses.** Laughing, adjusting, pretending to hold it, push it, kiss it. The usual madness.

Sometimes, the greatest monuments are those built on fragile ground. The tilt doesn't represent failure—it represents the beauty of standing tall despite the flaws.

Day 2

Pisa & the Leaning Tower — A Quick History Tilt

The Leaning Tower is actually a **bell tower**, standing beside the **Pisa Cathedral and Baptistery** in the historic **Piazza dei Miracoli** (Square of Miracles).

Here's the cool part:

- **Height:** 55.86 meters on the low side, and 56.67 meters on the high—yes, that's how tilted it is.
- Started leaning during construction in the **12th century**, because of soft ground.
- The tilt worsened and reached 5.5° by 1990, but was reduced to **3.97°** after stabilization efforts between 1993–2001.
- **Galileo Galilei**, who lived in Pisa, famously used the tower to drop two cannonballs of different masses to demonstrate the law of free fall.

Imagine that—a quirky architectural mishap turned into a physics experiment that changed science forever. And now it's become a playground for thousands of photo poses.

But the drama wasn't over.

After Pisa, we boarded the train back to Florence—souvenirs in hand, smiles intact—and just when we thought the day was winding down, it gave us one last twist. At a station en route, we witnessed something straight out of an Indian street scene: **two men in full-blown physical combat**, yelling, fists flying, and the police stepping in to break it up. One man was injured. The train was delayed. Drama, Italian edition.

To make things spicier, we then **got off at the wrong Florence station**, and had to hop the next train to the right one. Plans? Florence and Pisa didn't care much for those. But in the end, it all lined up beautifully.

Because then came **Gustapizza**.

We walked to the famed spot with tired legs and eager stomachs, joined the crowd waiting outside, and spent nearly **two hours** in line. And every second was **worth it**. That pizza? **Divine**. A burst of basil, cheese, tomato—and the revelation that **olive oil is the Italian magic wand**. We drizzled. We savored. We were healed.

After dinner, we treated ourselves to **gelato from Venchi**, and what a dream that was – cold, creamy, and a little sinful. We even bought chocolates for our office folks... and later devoured them ourselves (zero regrets). The **weekend vibe in Florence** felt like a perfect soundtrack. Streets filled just enough to feel alive, but never overwhelming. Music in the air. Laughter spilling from cafés. It had the kind of balance that cities rarely pull off.

And then came the final logistical twist—Villa Costanza. Turns out there are **two**: one in the city and one way outside. Our bus from Naples had arrived at the wrong one, and our early morning bus to Venice was scheduled from the same distant spot.

But Harshit, being Harshit, figured out that a **nearby Flixbus stop** might get us there. At 4 a.m., we walked through quiet Florence, explained our saga to the driver, and they let us **hop on without charge**, saving us time and money. By **5 a.m.**, we reached the correct Villa Costanza and boarded the bus to Venice.

Florence wasn't part of our original dream itinerary. But now? I'm hooked. After Paris, it's Florence I want to return to most. Tuscany—your tomatoes, spices, pasta, herbs, and olive oil are what dreams

taste like.

This wasn't a perfect day. But it was a perfect Italian **memory**. One that started with mishaps and ended with pizza, gelato, and a city that quietly stole my heart.

Must-Visit Places in Florence

If you find yourself in Florence, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Uffizi Gallery:** Discover masterpieces of Renaissance art.
- **Florence Cathedral:** Marvel at the Duomo and climb the dome.
- **Ponte Vecchio:** Walk across this medieval stone arch bridge of shops.
- **Palazzo Vecchio:** Visit the historic fortress-town hall.
- **Basilica of Santa Croce:** Burial place of Michelangelo, Galileo, and Machiavelli.
- **Boboli Gardens:** Stroll through these grand historic sculpture gardens.
- **Pitti Palace:** Tour this sprawling Renaissance palace.
- **Accademia Gallery:** See Michelangelo's legendary David statue.

Must-Visit Places in Pisa

- **Leaning Tower of Pisa:** Climb the 294 steps for epic views.
- **Piazza dei Miracoli:** UNESCO-listed square of marble wonders.
- **Pisa Cathedral (Duomo):** Majestic Romanesque facade and murals.
- **Baptistry of St. John:** Renowned for its unique acoustics.
- **Camposanto Monumentale:** Quiet cemetery cloister with medieval frescoes.

Amalfi Coast: Lemons, Lost Stops & a Slice of Romance

Day 1

Arrival — Salerno, Vietri & the Road to Amalfi

Sometimes, the universe has its own plans. It throws a few curveballs just to see how you respond—and then, in its own mysterious way, makes it all worth it.

Our journey began with a train from **Roma Termini to Salerno, followed by a connection to Vietri Sul Mare**. We reached Salerno around 9:30 AM, only to discover that the train to Vietri wasn't running due to station work. After some confusion and a bit of hustle, we learned we had to take a bus instead.

But the surprises didn't stop there.

We boarded the bus thinking we were heading to Amalfi, only to realize—midway—that Vietri Sul Mare and Amalfi are two different places. We got off at Vietri, slightly bewildered, and met a couple from Pune who had made the same mistake. Misery loves company, right?

Now we had two choices: wait at Vietri for a bus to Amalfi or return to Salerno and catch a bus from there. The catch? Buses from Salerno to Amalfi run every two hours. If we missed one, we'd be stuck again. We took the gamble, rushed back to Salerno, and thanks to Harshit's quick thinking—managed to grab the next bus just in time. Bonus: we got great seats!

The ride from Salerno to Amalfi was nothing short of breathtaking. **The Tyrrhenian Sea** sparkled beside us, lemon groves lined the hills, and the air was filled with the scent of citrus and salt. No photo could do it justice. It was one of those rare moments where your brain just stops and soaks it all in.

We got off at Minori, one stop before Amalfi, since our apartment was just a short walk away. And what an apartment! It instantly became our second favorite after our Paris stay. A charming gate, a tiny garden, a fountain nearby, and the sea right across the road. Oh, and just two minutes from the famous **Pasticceria Sal De Riso—home to the legendary Delizia al Limone**.

We had 20 minutes to freshen up before catching the next bus to Amalfi. The host was still setting up the apartment, but we quickly changed, packed some snacks, and made it just in time.

Amalfi itself was beautiful, though a bit overhyped—at least the part we explored. Maybe Sorrento or Capri would've been more impressive. Still, the village charm, the coastal breeze, and the pizza we devoured by the sea (after lugging our bags around all day) made it all worthwhile.

Eventually, we gave in and dipped our feet into the sea. It was cold, but refreshing. We don't know how to swim, so we didn't venture far, but it was fun. We changed nearby, relaxed on the beach, and clicked one of our favorite photos ever. Harshit brought lemon sorbet to the shore, and we even bumped into the Pune couple again for a sweet goodbye.

We wandered through Amalfi village, tried a delicious **veg cuoppo from Cuoppo d'Amalfi**, sampled lemon chocolates, and even considered buying **limoncello**—but it was pricey, and honestly, I find alcohol bitter. Still, the lemon-infused everything—from pizza to desserts—was a delightful surprise.

Later, we met a honeymooning couple from Delhi who had just visited Capri. Their verdict? Expensive, but worth it.

We bought our tickets for the next day's journey back to Salerno and returned to Minori. And if your apartment is by the sea, honestly, you don't need anything else.

Dinner that night was magical. We dined at **Sal De Riso**, just steps from our apartment. Candlelight, sea breeze, soft music, and incredible food—it was the perfect romantic dinner with my Golu. Yes, Golu, not Harshit. That's how perfect it was.

They even customized a non-veg pizza into a veg one for us. From the pizza to the desserts to the chocolates—everything was top-notch. The only downside? The seating and cutlery charges were sky-high. But hey, it's Italy. We knew what we were signing up for.

We packed some macarons, and at the counter, a woman helped us while a futuristic machine handled the payment and change. Automation, Italian-style.

Day 2

Sea-Side Morning & Departure

Back at the apartment, we packed and slept early. Our next day started at 6 AM with a bus to Salerno, and a train from there to Naples. We made one last mistake—forgetting that Vietri Sul Mare station was closed and planning to get off there. But that's travel. You miss signs, you make mistakes, and you learn.

And sometimes, the universe throws in a lemon. But in Amalfi, that's just another way to make something sweet.

Must-Visit Places in Amalfi Coast

If you ever find yourself in the Amalfi region, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Amalfi Coast Drive:** Take a bus or drive along this breathtaking coastal cliff road.
- **Duomo di Amalfi:** Marvel at the grand steps and Moorish architecture of this cathedral.
- **Path of the Gods:** Hike this historic cliffside trail for infinite Tyrrhenian sea views.
- **Villa Rufolo:** Stroll through medieval gardens looking down onto the Ravello coastline.
- **Grotta dello Smeraldo:** Explore the emerald green lights inside this natural sea cave.
- **Fiordo di Furore:** Snap photos of the dramatic high bridge over a hidden rocky beach gorge.
- **Amalfi Paper Museum:** Discover ancient medieval watermill paper craft.
- **Valle delle Ferriere:** Hike among streams and lush waterfalls in this quiet valley.

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